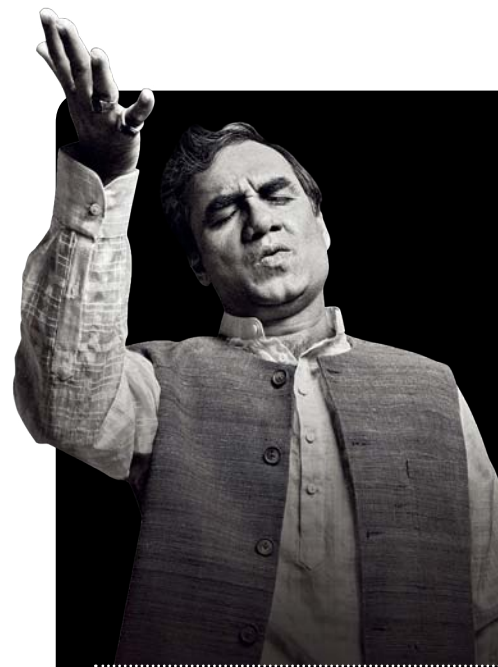
PLAYING THE NETA

AS ELECTION SEASON DRAWS NEAR, CINEMA BECOMES A VEHICLE TO SHOWCASE ***POLITICAL ICONS AS EITHER HEROES OR VILLAINS***

By SUHANI SINGH

In 2019, just a few months before the Lok Sabha election, came two political dramas. The first, *The Accidental Prime Minister*, based on Sanjaya Baru's book of the same name, offered the portrait of a Prime Minister Manmohan Singh (Anupam Kher) subservient to the Gandhis. The second, *PM Narendra Modi* (Vivek Oberoi), was a poorly made hagiography. Both were duds at the box office. Four years later, with elections just a year away, audiences can expect an onslaught of political films likely to generate as much conversation as controversy.

Of these, two will feature portrayals of India's own Iron Lady, Indira Gandhi. The first, *Emergency* (release date to be announced), has Kangana Ranaut producing, directing and acting in the film. In the second, the Meghna Gulzar-directed *Sam Bahadur*, starring Vicky Kaushal as Field



MAIN ATAL HOON

Release date: In December
Dir: Ravi Jadhav
Pankaj Tripathi is grateful to get the opportunity to play Vajpayee, a "unique personality" in his many avatars–as "a PM, a poet, a statesman and a gentleman".

SWATANTRAVEER SAVARKAR

Release date: May 16
Dir: Randeep Hooda
After filmmaker Mahesh Manjrekar exited the project, Hooda stepped up to direct the biopic on the divisive figure of V.D. Savarkar, whose profile has risen with the Hindutva tide.



BHAGWA DHWAJ (working title)

Release date: to be announced
Dir: K.V. Vijayendra Prasad
The RSS has roped in Prasad, screenwriter of the two Bahubali films and RRR, to write and direct this big-budgeted drama that celebrates the organisation's rise and growing influence.